

month to reflect the balance on the statement you receive from your brokerage, bank, or mutual fund.

Shop Around

Some of the most popular personal-finance software programs for automating your checkbook and tracking your expenses are Quicken, Mint, and Moneydance. These are available for purchase online or at big office supply stores such as Staples.



To purchase Quicken, visit www.intuit.com; for Mint, go to www.mint.com; for Moneydance, hit www.moneydance.com. All three software packages are also available for purchase at www.amazon.com. The basic version of each software package costs between \$30 and \$40 after rebates.

A program like Quicken has many features you'll probably never use, but it is also a great program for the average person who just wants to do online banking, automatically reconcile their bank statement, track expenses, budget, prepare for tax time, and print reports. The budget versus actual report alone is worth the investment. Moneydance is a simpler program that is not as well-known, but it provides the same basic features without all the fancy bells and whistles.